



The Fault Lines

- Ravidassias worship idols of Guru Ravidass and late heads of Dera Ballan along with the Guru Granth Sahib.
- Ravidass is considered a guru and so are the Dera heads.
- Their last names are Dass, perhaps taken from their guru's name.
- Sikhs consider Ravidass as a "bhakta". For them no living person can be a guru.
- They accept the ten gurus and the Guru Granth Sahib as their only guru.
- Sikhs in most cases keep their last name as Singh.

Origins of Dera Ballan

Sant Pipal Dass founded it at the beginning of the 20th century when he lost his wife after which he left home with his son Sarwan Dass in search of truth.

The saints of Ballan developed their own religious symbols, flags, prayers, dress, salutations, and rituals of worship.

Even the architecture of Dera Ballan is unique as it resembles both a temple and a gurudwara at the same time.

Ballan saints wear turban, keep unshorn hair and flowing beards, like Sikh priests even though one of the late heads of Dera Ballan, Sant Garib Dass, was clean-shaven.

identity, independent of both Sikhism and Hinduism," says Ronki Ram, a political science professor who has done extensive research on the Dera. "It is in this context that Dera Ballan has emerged as an alternative religious site for the Dalits with its own code of conduct that paved the way for a separate Dalit identity," says Ram.

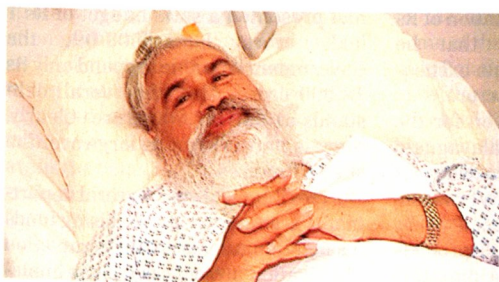
A Ravidass gurudwara has the idols of Guru Ravidass and the late

head of Dera Ballan along with the Guru Granth Sahib. Ravidass is considered a guru and so are the *gaddi nashins* (heads) of the Deras. Sant Niranjani Dass is the fifth *gaddi nashin* at Dera Ballan. This is not acceptable to Sikhs who consider Ravidass as a "bhakta" and rever only the 10 gurus and the Guru Granth Sahib—an issue that has pitted the community and Jat Sikhs against each other. Yet the

Ravidass community has grown and become assertive with Ravidass gurudwaras coming up across the world.

The Vienna incident was evidently triggered after a Ravidass gurudwara came up in 2006, causing some resentment among radical Sikhs. "Every year maharajji had been visiting it for religious discourses. But to my knowledge there was no problem. We believe in peace and preach peace," says the Dera Sach Khand spokesman S.R. Heer.

Sources, however, do point out to rising discontent among Sikh radicals. Yet the Deras grow, especially with political parties giving them patronage, knowing that these form formidable votebanks and annoying these could harm their political interests. That's why when violence taking place in faraway Vienna causes Punjab to erupt, political leaders choose to term the reaction as "spontaneous". ■



SANT NIRANJANI DASS AT A VIENNA HOSPITAL WHERE HE WAS OPERATED FOR GUNSHOT WOUNDS